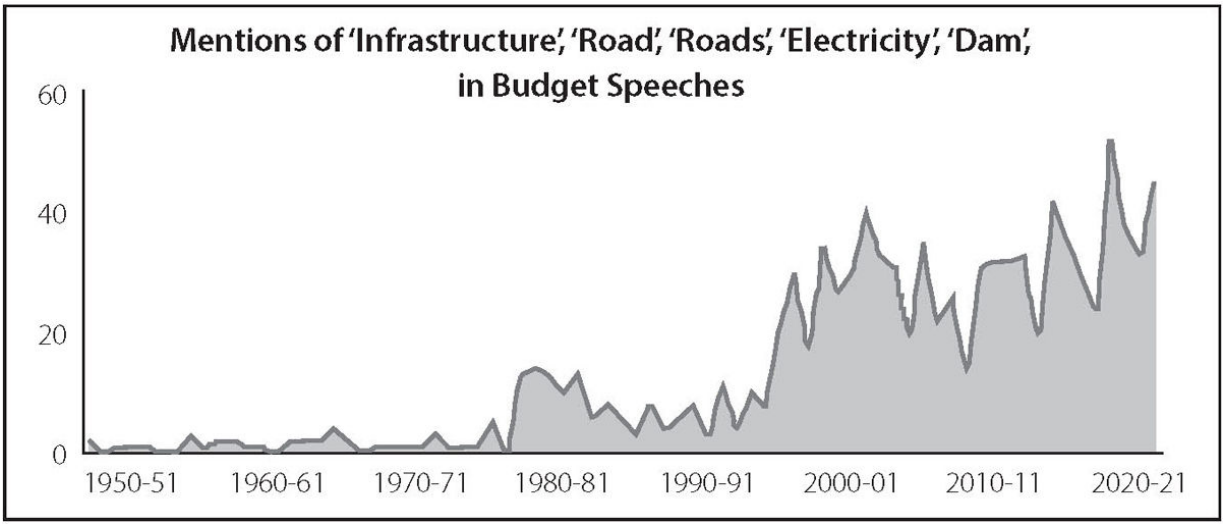
on it. Modi inherited this legacy as prime minister and spiked it to significantly higher levels.

Figure 10.12: The Modi Government's Focus on Infrastructure Is Greater than That of Any Previous Regime (Budget Speeches: 1950-51 to 2020-21)



Source: Budget speeches by Union finance ministers. Analysis by Rishabh Srivastava, Nalin Mehta, PollNiti

In practice, the Modi government significantly upped total infrastructure expenditure (₹726 crore in 2018-19 to ₹972 crore in 2020-21).[102] The biggest increases were in railways, where private operators have been offered 150 routes in public–private partnerships, and in highways, where the government aimed at a build-up of 11,000 km in 2018, up from 9,328 km in 2017-18, and more than twice the rate at which UPA-2 built (see Figures 10.13 and 10.14).[103] Railways have long been a state monopoly, but the government's domination of the sector is expected to ease up with private players taking up several services.

The proposal for leasing certain railway services to private players was expected to supplement the government's 'asset recycling' plan, as Swaminathan Aiyar put it. Since 2018, the government has been 'auctioning rights to operate, maintain and share toll revenue from existing infrastructure—roads, ports, power stations and transmission lines. Cash from old infrastructure is